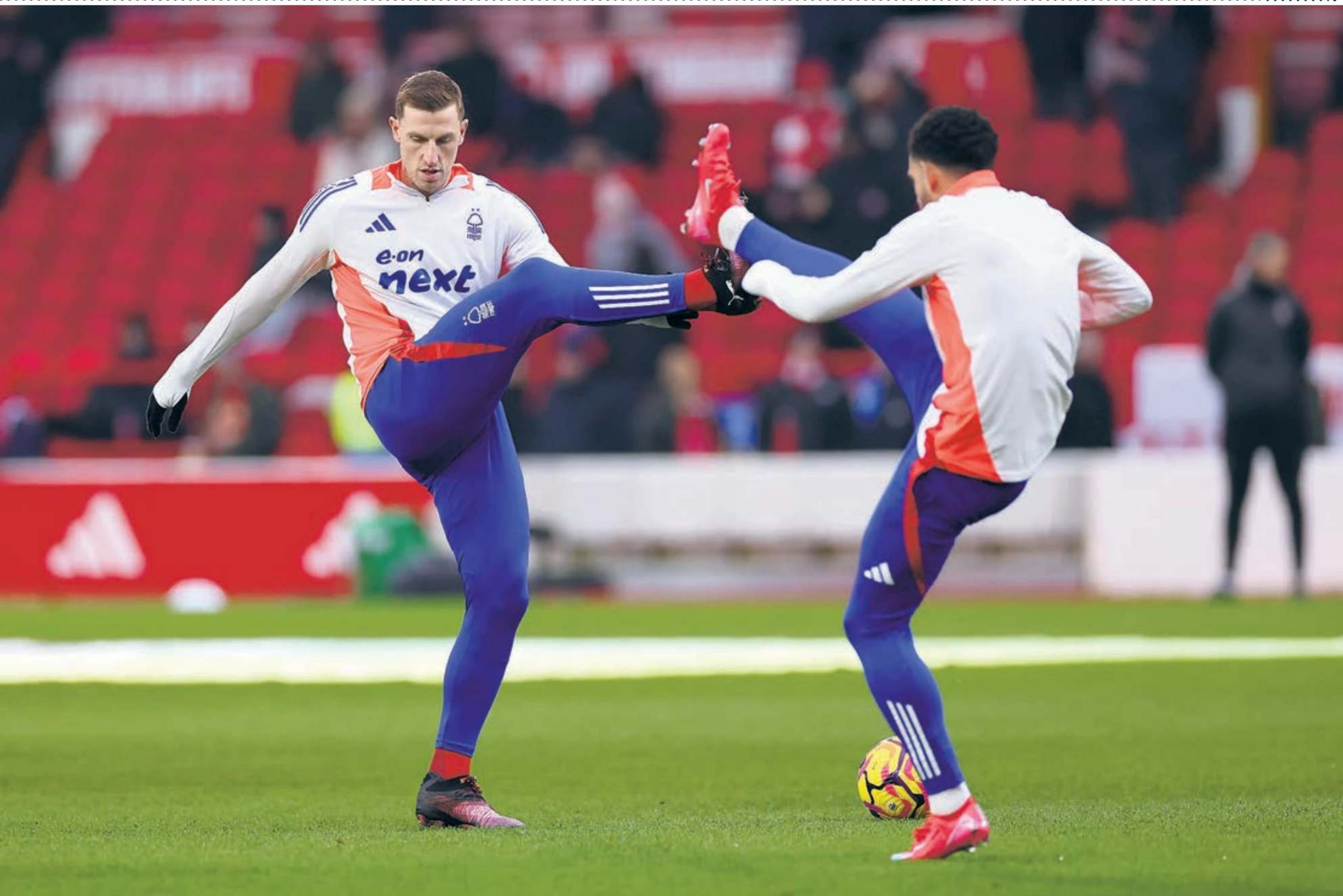




athletes often undertake 10 or more training sessions per week, while others may train six or more sessions weekly. Reducing frequency by a couple of sessions may be more suitable for elite athletes than for those already training at lower frequencies.

Training age

Training age refers to the accumulation of training time over an athlete's career and is also considered a component in this tapering equation. It does not mean that athletes with low training ages are necessarily young athletes.

The fundamental idea is that greater training age generally produces better athletes compared to those with lower training ages. Here, chronological age is irrelevant.

A useful analogy is to compare two identical hypercars: one operating at 90-100 per cent capacity and the other at 40-50 per cent capacity. The car with higher work capacity places greater

stress on its components than the lower-capacity car, resulting in significantly different performance. The higher-capacity car also requires more maintenance, recovery, and fuel to sustain its performance. The same principle applies when comparing elite athletes to novice athletes.

Athletes in their 20s who have trained for only a few months have a lower training age than a 19-year-old who has been training consistently for two to three years, despite being older chronologically. Athletes with lower training ages are more likely to be further from their genetic potential.

Type of athlete

Each athlete responds differently to volume, intensity, and frequency adjustments. While the general guidelines are suitable for most athletes, outliers may require tailored modifications to their tapering plans. Coaches must adjust these components based on individual needs. When is an athlete best

The right balance: If tapering begins too early, the athlete may peak prematurely, leading to a decline in performance. Conversely, if tapering begins too late, the athlete may still be fatigued, which can negatively impact performance. GETTY IMAGES

positioned to achieve peak performance? If tapering begins too early, the athlete may peak prematurely, leading to a decline in performance. Conversely, if tapering begins too late, the athlete may still be fatigued, which can negatively impact performance.

Coaches and athletes should carefully determine the optimal timing for tapering, taking into account volume, frequency, and intensity, to ensure peak performance at the right time. Since every athlete is unique, it is essential for both coach and athlete to identify the combination that works best for them.